

Word family: **minute / minutes / minutely**

Base word: minute

Plural: minutes

Related form: minutely

Important pronunciation split:

* **minute** /'mɪnɪt/ = time unit; moment; meeting record

* **minute** /maɪ'nju:t/ = extremely small / very detailed

Useful expressions / extensions: one minute...the next, wait a minute, any minute, minute by minute, the last minute, minutes of a meeting, minute detail

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective (形容詞) / verb (動詞 , 正式 / 行政用法)

Your sentence:

> “**One minute**, the living room becomes a space station, and **the next** it turns into a jungle, a castle, or even a rescue centre.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **minute** does **not** literally mean an exact period of sixty seconds.

The construction:

> **one minute ... the next**

means:

> **at one moment something is one way, and almost immediately afterward it is completely different**

It emphasizes how quickly Leo's imagination changes the scene.

繁體中文： ** 前一刻 / 一下子；表示一個很短的時間點，之後情況很快便改變

**中文翻譯： **

> “One minute, the living room becomes a space station, and the next it turns into a jungle...”

「前一分鐘 / 前一刻」，客廳還變成太空站；下一刻，它就變成叢林.....」

Natural Chinese here is better as:

> **「前一刻.....下一刻.....」**

rather than insisting on a literal sixty-second minute.

1. **minute = 60 seconds (分鐘) — 分鐘**

The basic time-unit meaning.

Practice 1

> “Wait five **minutes**.”

「等五**分鐘**。」

Practice 2

> “The journey takes about thirty **minutes**.”

「車程大約需要三十**分鐘**。」

minute = 一小時的六十分之一，即六十秒

2. **one minute ... the next (前一刻.....下一刻.....) — 一下子；轉眼間**

This is the exact sense/construction in your passage.

Practice 3 — Original

> “**One minute**, the living room becomes a space station, and **the next** it turns into a jungle.”

「**前一刻**，客廳變成太空站；**下一刻**，它就變成叢林。」

Practice 4

> “**One minute** he’s laughing, and **the next** he’s completely serious.”

「他**前一刻**還在笑，**下一刻**就完全嚴肅起來。」

Practice 5

> “**One minute** the sky was clear, and **the next** it was pouring.”

「天空**前一刻**還很晴朗，**下一刻**就下起大雨。」

one minute ... the next = 表示兩種情況在很短時間內迅速轉換

The important meaning is **rapid change**, not precise clock time.

3. **minute** = very short period / moment (一會兒) — 一下 ; 片刻

A common informal extension from the time unit.

Practice 6

> “Can I speak to you for a **minute**?”

「我可以跟你談**一下**嗎？」

Practice 7

> “Give me a **minute** to think.”

「給我**一點**時間 / 等我**一下**想想。」

a minute = 一小段不精確的時間；不一定真的只有六十秒

This is extremely common in conversation.

4. **wait a minute** (等一下) — 等一下 ; 慢著

A major fixed expression.

Practice 8

> “**Wait a minute**—that doesn’t make sense.”

「**等一下 / 慢著**——那說不通。」

Practice 9

> “**Just a minute**, please.”

「請**稍等**一下。」

wait/just a minute = 要求對方短暫等待；亦可用來突然停下來重新思考某事

The second use can mean:

> 「慢著，我剛想到……」

rather than literally waiting.

5. **any minute (隨時；很快) — 隨時；馬上**

Practice 10

> “She should arrive **any minute**.”

「她應該**隨時都會到 / 很快就到**。」

Practice 11

> “The bus could come **any minute now**.”

「巴士現在**隨時都可能來**。」

any minute = 某件事預期很快發生，可能就在接下來極短時間內

6. **minute by minute (每分鐘；逐分鐘) — 每分鐘；一分一分地**

Practice 12

> “The situation changed **minute by minute**.”

「情況**每一分鐘都在變化**。」

Practice 13

> “Her condition improved **minute by minute**.”

「她的情況**逐分鐘改善**。」

minute by minute = 每一小段時間持續變化；逐分鐘地

Can be literal or slightly figurative.

7. **at the last minute (最後一刻) — 最後關頭；臨時**

A very common expression.

Practice 14

> “He changed his mind **at the last minute**.”

「他在**最後一刻**改變主意。」

Practice 15

> “Don’t leave everything until the **last minute**.”

「不要甚麼都拖到**最後一刻**才做。」

at the last minute = 在最後可能的時刻，幾乎已經沒有時間剩下

8. **a minute ago** (剛才) — 一分鐘前；剛剛

Practice 16

> “He was here a **minute ago**.”

「他**剛剛**還在這裡。」

Practice 17

> “I saw her a few **minutes ago**.”

「我幾**分鐘前**見過她。」

a minute ago = 一分鐘前；口語中亦可較鬆散地表示「剛才」

9. **minute** = one-sixtieth of a degree (角分) — 角分

A genuine technical measurement sense.

Practice 18

> “One degree contains sixty **minutes** of arc.”

「一度包含六十個**角分**。」

Practice 19

> “The angle was measured in degrees and **minutes**.”

「這個角度以度和**角分**量度。」

minute = 角度單位，等於一度的六十分之一

This is normally written:

> 1'

and is mainly technical/scientific.

10. **minute hand** (分針) — 分針

Practice 20

> “The **minute hand** is pointing at twelve.”

「**分針**正指向十二。」

Practice 21

> “The **minute hand** moves faster than the hour hand.”

「**分針**比時針走得快。」

minute hand = 時鐘上顯示分鐘的較長指針

This is a useful compound based directly on the time-unit sense.

11. **minutes** = official written record of a meeting (會議紀錄) — 會議紀錄

A major separate noun meaning, normally plural.

Practice 22

> “Did you read the **minutes** of the meeting?”

「你看過那次會議的**會議紀錄**嗎？」

Practice 23

> “The secretary prepared the **minutes**.”

「秘書準備了**會議紀錄**。」

minutes = 正式記錄會議中討論事項、決定和行動項目的文件

This is **not** about how many minutes the meeting lasted.

12. **take / keep minutes (記錄會議內容) — 做會議紀錄**

Practice 24

> “Who is taking the **minutes** today?”

「今天由誰負責**做會議紀錄**？」

Practice 25

> “She kept detailed **minutes** of the discussion.”

「她為討論內容做了詳細的**會議紀錄**。」

take/keep minutes = 正式記錄會議內容和決定

13. **minute — verb = formally record in meeting minutes (記入會議紀錄) — 記錄**

A formal administrative verb.

Practice 26

> “The decision was **minuted**.”

「這項決定已被**記入會議紀錄**。」

Practice 27

> “Please ensure that the objection is **minuted**.”

「請確保這項反對意見被**正式記錄在會議紀錄中**。」

****minute something = 正式把某事記入會議紀錄****

Register:

> formal / administrative, especially British English

14. ****minute /maɪ'nju:t/ = extremely small (極小的) — 微小的 ; 極細小的****

Now we have the major ****pronunciation-changing homograph****.

Practice 28

> “The machine contains ****minute**** parts.”

「這部機器內有一些非常****微小的零件****。」

Practice 29

> “Only a ****minute**** amount was detected.”

「只檢測到****極微量****。」

****minute /maɪ'nju:t/ = extremely small in size, amount, or degree****

This is completely different from:

> minute /'mɪnɪt/ = 分鐘

15. ****minute detail (微細細節) — 極細微的細節****

A very common use of the adjective.

Practice 30

> “She noticed every ****minute detail****.”

「她注意到每一個****極細微的細節****。」

Practice 31

> “The painting was examined in ****minute detail****.”

「這幅畫被以**極細緻的程度**檢查。」

minute detail = 非常細小、不容易被注意到的細節

16. **minute difference/change (細微差異 / 變化) — 極小的差別**

Practice 32

> “There is only a **minute difference** between the two versions.”

「兩個版本之間只有**極細微的差別**。」

Practice 33

> “The temperature showed a **minute change**.”

「溫度只出現了**非常細微的變化**。」

minute = 小到很難察覺或程度極低的

17. **minutely = in very great detail (極詳細地) — 細緻地；詳盡地**

A related adverb.

Practice 34

> “The evidence was examined **minutely**.”

「證據被**極仔細地**檢查。」

Practice 35

> “She described the scene **minutely**.”

「她把現場**極為詳細地**描述出來。」

minutely = 極仔細、極詳細地，留意非常微小的細節

Pronunciation follows the adjective family:

> /maɪ'nju:tli/

Important distinction: **minute** /'mɪnɪt/ vs minute /maɪ'nju:t/

This is the biggest issue with this word.

minute /'mɪnɪt/

= 分鐘 / 短時間

> “Wait a minute.”

minute /maɪ'nju:t/

= 極小的 / 細微的

> “a minute difference”

Same spelling, **different pronunciation and meaning**.

This is exactly the kind of pronunciation-sensitive polysemy/homography worth flagging.

Important distinction: **minute** vs **moment**

minute

can mean an exact sixty-second unit:

> “Wait two minutes.”

moment

is normally an indefinite short period:

> “Wait a moment.”

But informal:

> “Give me a minute.”

often behaves like **moment** and does not promise exactly sixty seconds.

Important distinction: **minute vs second**

minute

= 60 seconds.

second

= 1/60 of a minute.

But both can be used loosely:

> “Wait a minute.”

> “Wait a second.”

Both may simply mean:

> 「等一下。」

Important distinction: **one minute...the next vs every minute**

one minute...the next

emphasizes rapid change:

> “One minute he’s happy, the next he’s angry.”

every minute

means each sixty-second interval or very frequently:

> “The situation changes every minute.”

Different constructions.

Important distinction: **one minute...the next vs first...then**

first ... then

simply gives sequence.

****one minute ... the next****

adds:

> very quick, striking, often surprising change.

Your passage could say:

> “First the room is a space station, then it becomes a jungle.”

But:

> “One minute ... the next ...”

makes Leo's imagination feel ****faster and more vivid****.

Important distinction: ****a minute vs for a minute****

****a minute****

can be an object of duration:

> “It took a minute.”

****for a minute****

explicitly marks how long something lasts:

> “I waited for a minute.”

In informal English both may refer loosely to a short time.

Important distinction: ****any minute vs in a minute****

****any minute****

= very soon, at an uncertain moment.

> “She’ll arrive any minute.”

****in a minute****

= after a short time.

> “I’ll call you in a minute.”

So:

****any minute = 隨時****

****in a minute = 過一會兒****

Important distinction: **last minute vs final minute**

**last-minute decision**

often means:

> made very late, just before the deadline/event.

**final minute**

can literally mean:

> the last sixty seconds.

> “They scored in the final minute.”

So the idiomatic ****last minute**** is broader.

Important distinction: **minutes — time vs meeting record**

Compare:

> “The meeting lasted sixty ****minutes****.”

= 會議持續六十分鐘。

versus:

> “I read the meeting ****minutes****.”

= 我看了會議紀錄。

Same plural spelling, completely different meaning.

Important distinction: **minute** adjective vs **tiny**

tiny

ordinary everyday English:

> “a tiny insect”

minute /maɪˈnju:t/

more formal:

> “minute particles”

Both mean very small, but **minute** often appears in:

* scientific

* technical

* formal descriptive writing

Important distinction: **minute** vs **minor**

minute

= extremely small in size, amount, or degree.

minor

= relatively unimportant or not serious.

> “a minute difference”

= 極細微差異

> “a minor problem”

= 小問題 / 不嚴重問題

A difference can be minute but still important.

Important distinction: **minute detail** vs **detailed**

minute detail

= extremely small individual details.

detailed

= containing a lot of information/detail overall.

> “a detailed report”

does not mean:

> the report is physically tiny.

Important distinction: **minutely** vs **every minute**

They look deceptively similar.

minutely /maɪˈnjuːtli/

= in extremely fine detail

> “examined minutely”

every minute

= once in each minute / continuously

Completely different.

Family-extension note

Minute is an especially worthwhile polysemy/homograph candidate because it combines several distinct modern branches:

* **60-second time unit**

* **informal short period** → give me a minute

* **rapid-change construction** → one minute...the next
 * **technical angular unit**
 * **meeting minutes**
 * **formal verb: minute a decision**
 * **minute /maɪ'nju:t/ = extremely small**
 * **minutely = in very fine detail**

This entry also illustrates why the scanning SOP specifically checks **pronunciation changes**: the two pronunciations signal a major lexical split that learners can easily miss.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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minute — time unit	一小時的六十分之一，即六十秒
one minute...the next	表示兩種情況在很短時間內快速、明顯地轉換
a minute — short period	一段很短但不一定精確為六十秒的時間
wait a minute	要求短暫等待；亦可表示「慢著」
any minute	某件事預期隨時、很快發生
minute by minute	每分鐘 / 隨著每一小段時間持續變化
at the last minute	在最後可能時刻、幾乎沒有時間剩下時
minute — angular unit	等於一度六十分之一的角度單位
minute hand	時鐘上顯示分鐘的指針
minutes — meeting record	正式記錄會議討論、決定和行動項目的文件
take minutes	正式記錄會議內容
minute — verb	把某事正式記入會議紀錄
minute /maɪ'nju:t/ — tiny	尺寸、數量或程度極其細小的
minute detail	非常細小、不容易察覺的細節
minute difference	程度極低、非常細微的差別
minutely	以極仔細、極詳細、注意微小細節的方式

For your original sentence

> “**One minute**, the living room becomes a space station, and **the next** it turns into a jungle, a castle, or even a rescue centre.”

The exact meaning is:

one minute ... the next = 前一刻還是某種情況，下一刻便迅速變成另一種完全不同的情況

Therefore:

> **one minute ... the next**

= **「前一刻.....下一刻..... / 一下子又變成.....」**

It does **not** mean that Leo literally waits exactly sixty seconds before changing the imaginary world.

The phrase emphasizes:

> **speed + contrast + rapid imaginative change**

So compared with:

> “First it becomes a space station, then it becomes a jungle,”

the original:

> **“One minute ... the next ...”**

makes his imagination feel much more **quick-moving, spontaneous, and lively**.